

The Vision of Nalanda

(C. 425–C. 1350 CE)

‘We Bihari *log* know the reputation we have, from America to Dubai,’ the taxi driver, Kaaru, says in Magadhi-inflected Hindi, his tone a mixture of hurt pride and irritation. I had asked him about the safety of Bihar’s roads after dark. We are heading south-east from Patna to Bihar Sharif, my base camp for the ruins of Nalanda Mahavihara, the Buddhist monastery often called the first university in the world, where subjects like grammar, logic, philosophy, theology, astronomy and medicine were taught to resident monks from across Asia. When I last visited in 2006, highway robberies were common. ‘But no danger now,’ Kaaru reassures me. ‘Nitish Kumar’, Bihar’s chief minister for much of the time since my last visit, ‘has finished off the highway gangs’.

We soon hit a traffic jam. A truck has overturned ahead. Expecting a long delay, Kaaru turns us around, gets off the highway and takes a rural road that will reconnect us to the highway ahead of the overturned truck. It’s the monsoon season and the landscape glows a radiant green in the afternoon sun. Women plant rice in fields with standing water. Other fields have corn or vegetables. Unpainted walls of village homes carry ads for hakims of the traditional Yunani system of medicine, claiming to fix *gupt rog* (hidden diseases) and restore *mardana taakat* (masculine strength)—euphemisms for sundry sexual ailments and anxieties where talking about them is still a